

Location-based Photos

Flickr has announced a service called "Places," wherein images can be mapped to the location where the picture was taken. You "open up the Map tab, find the place you took the photo, and then drop your photo on the place you took it."



TV Channels Via The Internet

Sync TV recently launched a test to offer viewers the ability to download content from the TV channels they subscribe to. Programmes are broadcast through the Internet, and the subscription fee ranges from \$2 to \$4 per month per channel or \$2 per episode.



newsbytes



DRM

Welcome to the world of DRM—Digital Rights Management. We Indians haven't felt the full impact of it yet, but we do sympathise with the poor fish that do...

DRM (The Other Acronym)

Digital Restrictions Management, as the Free Software Foundation likes to call it—the idea is that DRM doesn't tell you what your rights are, but what they *aren't*.

FairPlay Possibly the one that started this mess. FairPlay is Apple's DRM solution—every song bought from iTunes comes with it, making the song unusable on more than 5 PCs, but usable on any number of iPods.

WMDRM The Windows Media DRM scheme, which you will find on all music downloaded from the Zune marketplace. Microsoft even stays a step ahead of the pirates, updating the DRM algorithm regularly, so even if it got cracked, it rarely stayed cracked.

FairUse4WM, DoubleTwist Intrepid young hackers decided that they'd had enough, and developed these schemes that would rip the DRM out of Apple and Microsoft's music downloads respectively.

Usage I like my music DRM-free man, but even if I had to, FairPlay seems to be...well...the fairest. And before I upgrade and all my music turns to junk, there's always FairUse4WM and DoubleTwist to get me out of *that* nonsense!

BLOOPER

Steal This Film Gets Stolen

BitTorrent is a technology that uses peer to peer (P2P) technology to share files between users, and it is most commonly used to download movies and music illegally over the Internet. Last year, the first half of a two-part documentary called *Steal This Film*, highlighting the raids on top BitTorrent sites and the effect it had on its users, was released. In true-blue BitTorrent style, Part 2 leaked onto BitTorrent sites before the release date.

The illegal recording is speculated to have occurred during its first screening at Oil For The 21st Century conference in Berlin.

Excuse us whilst we take a moment to L our collective As off—talk about the mother of all ironies! Of course, this would have been a lot funnier if the creators ran around screaming "You stole my movie! To the courtrooms!", but no—that only happens when children do something silly like film a few seconds of *The Simpsons Movie* on their cell phones. Compared to that, producer Jaime King's attitude is remarkably less entertaining: our hero is actually happy that the movie got was released on the BitTorrent networks—and this is what he had to say: "We think people should better not watch it, as we'll track them down via haxxoring their IPs and sue their asses off," he continues "Seriously, we're

delighted anyone would want to make a cam of *STFII*. We hope anyone that keen to watch it will enjoy it despite the dip in quality, and for those that want to wait, it's only a few days until release."

Warning: spoiler ahead!

Part 2 features the administrators behind the top two BitTorrent sites, their opinion of the P2P and BitTorrent revolution, and how file sharing will be a part of the future and shape the world we live in. Let's hope this one features more interviews of people other than those from The Pirate Bay.

MANIA

Movie Producer Thanks Pirates

Ah, if only we had more film-makers like these... First there's Jaime King saying "wait till we put it on the torrent network ourselves", and now, continuing with the P2P love, Eric Wilkinson, producer of *The Man From Earth*, recently wrote to the BitTorrent site www.rlslog.com, thanking them for stealing his film and putting it up for download. Confused yet? Read on...

It's not always smooth sailing when you're an

independent, low-budget movie producer, even more so when you have no advertising budget to promote your film. For these very reasons, Eric found the going tough for his recently-made movie. Then something strange happened—his Web site clocked 25,000 hits in a fortnight, the International Movie Database (IMdB) ranking of his movie went from being an obscure 11,235 to fifth-most popular movie. It so happens that his film got ripped and uploaded to the BitTorrent sites from where users downloaded the movie. Not only that, they bumped up the IMdB ranking of the movie too!

Wilkinson seems very pleased with the whole experience—and has this to say: "What you guys have done here is nothing short of amazing. In the future, I will not complain about file sharing. YOU HAVE HELPED PUT THIS LITTLE MOVIE ON THE MAP!!!!"



When I make my next picture, I just may upload the movie on the net myself!"

One happy soul for all the wrong reasons, but it's the result that matters...

WHAT'S GOING ON?

One Size That Fits None

As the war between HD-DVD and Blu-ray intensifies—not to mention get more boring, tedious and maybe even pointless—the customer is at the receiving end of all the bovine excreta (as, let's face it, he has always been). Potential customers are as confused as ever, and early adopters are losing their money. Traditionally, a single layer Blu-ray disc would have 25 GB capacity, and HD-DVD, 15 GB. With the use of dual-layer technology, these discs have been pepped up to 50 GB and 30 GB respectively, and can be played in supported players. Today, 44 per cent of Blu-ray titles use the 50 GB disc, and 56



per cent use the 25 GB disc. Almost all the HD-DVD movies available in the market are in the 30 GB dual-layer format.

While major Hollywood production houses and manufacturers themselves are divided on what format their movies and hardware will support, the early adopters have no option but to go with one of the technologies and watch only movies released by the supporting production houses... at the price, that's a terrible thing to do, if you're a true movie buff. And so many are...

There were also a bunch of "better than Blu-Ray / HD-DVD" optical technologies—one of our favourites is Warner's Total HD disk, which features Blu-Ray on one side, and HD-HD-DVD on the other. Early 2008 should tell us how those fare. Then there's China's EVD standard, which claims to be able to squeeze an HD movie on to a DVD using the same old red laser technology. Turns out that it wasn't developed to compete with the Big Two, but was a (rather sneaky) way to get Chinese disc player manufacturers to avoid shelling out the hefty royalties they must to be able to manufacture players that'll play Blu-Ray or HD-DVD disks. As such, even if it does meet with success (unlikely), it'll only be in China.

Other optical disc manufacturers, on the other hand, have been upping the capacity of the two competing disc

technologies by adding layers. Ritek, for example, recently demonstrated the possibility of adding 10 layers to both kinds of discs, to bring the capacity of Blu-Ray to 250 GB and HD-DVD to 150 GB respectively. But the catch: current players do not support such layers. With the DVD Forum recently having approved the 51 GB triple-layer HD-DVD specification, owners of current HD-DVD players are left to fend for themselves due to incompatibility issues. And then, with HD-DVD reaching Blu-ray capacities, it won't be long before Blu-ray goes ahead to become, well, 250 GB. So when is the right time to buy the right player? We don't know. Sorry.

AGAINST PRECEDENT

The Pirate Bay Set For Shutdown?

Swedish prosecutors recently announced the date for shutdown of the world's most popular torrent tracker The Pirate Bay—end of January next year. The announcement comes when investigations are underway relating to financial involvement by Carl Lundstorm, who is also a major financier of the Swedish Democrats. Pirate Bay's administrator Peter Sunde, too, is being prosecuted for copyright infringement.

The Pirate Bay is likely to say, in its defence, that it is a search engine that only directs users to downloads—a popular loophole that torrent sites exploit ("Torrent files don't contain the movie, so we're in the clear"). That statement was earlier used by Alan Ellis, founder of Oink, the world's largest pirate music file sharing site, to bail himself out. But the question is, obviously, can BitTorrent and the likes be really shut down?

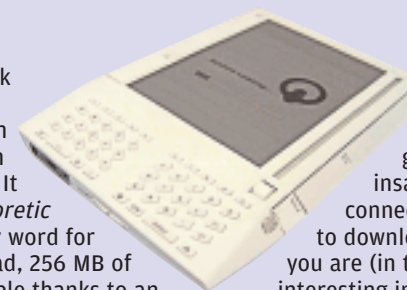
Think back: early last year, The Pirate Bay at Stockholm was raided by Swedish police, who took their servers away and put the site offline for three days. When it came back online, its new hosting site was in The Netherlands, and this time round, they had even taken measures to reduce restoration time. The seizures also prompted The Pirate Bay to plan to buy 550 square metres of a self-declared nation called Sealand—formerly a British naval platform in the North Sea, nominated a "micronation." This, outside the jurisdiction of any country, could be a safe haven for hosting the site.

Renewed charges have now given rise to new ideas—those that make it even more difficult for the law enforcers—changing the BitTorrent protocol itself! The new protocol is supposed to avoid malware, spam, and mainly, the attention of the law.

It's been fun to watch for quite some time now, and it's just going to get even more fun.

Kindle

Amazon's just given e-book reading a shot in the arm with the new Kindle, which should place a nasty thorn in the Sony Reader's side. It sports a 6-inch *electrophoretic* display (that's just a fancy word for e-paper), a QWERTY keypad, 256 MB of internal storage—extendable thanks to an



SD slot—mini-USB connectivity, and best of all, it'll connect to the Internet using *EV-DO* (that's high-speed Internet via CDMA)! So you've got an e-book reader that can store an insane number of books, and can then connect to Amazon's impending Kindle store to download more e-books—no matter where you are (in the USA, at least)! This should be very interesting indeed...

Buzzword
of the MONTH